

Assumed Knowledge — what the series never teaches and leans on anyway

Written before checking the documents, same discipline as `Exam.md`.

`Exam.md` asked whether the seasons answer what they promise. **This asks the opposite question: what do they use without ever explaining?** Every item below is something a script says, or depends on, while assuming the person saying it already knows what it means.

Why this file exists

Two failure modes, and they are different.

On camera. The pass condition is one take, cold. **A term you have used but never had to define is exactly where a take dies**, because you reach for the explanation and it is not there, and it is not there because the document never needed it to be.

In the comments. Every one of these is a question a viewer can ask, and the series' whole posture is *go and check*. **An unanswerable comment is a worse result here than in an ordinary channel**, because this series is specifically about not overclaiming.

The rule for what belongs on this list

Not everything unexplained is a gap. **A term is a gap when the argument leans on it.** `z = 3` needs the viewer to know what a standard deviation is, so that is a gap. The date of Diodorus is decoration, so it is not.

Test: if a viewer answered this wrongly, would they misunderstand a conclusion? If yes it is on the list. If no it is trivia.

Grades, fixed now

GRADE	MEANING
T	taught somewhere in Seasons 1 to 3
N	not taught, and notes now written below
X	not taught and does not need to be, by the rule above

Contamination disclosure

Same as `Exam.md`: **I have read every episode**. That biases me toward listing things I remember being explained. **The N rows are the result. The T rows are not evidence of anything.**

1. What is a median, and why does this project report medians rather than means?
2. What is a standard deviation, and what does $z = 3$ mean in plain words?
3. What is a permutation test, and why use one instead of a t-test?
4. Why 2,000 permutations rather than 200 or 200,000? What does the number buy?
5. What does $p < 0.05$ mean, and where does 0.05 come from? Is it principled?
6. What is e , and why does the Poisson zero formula use it?
7. What does Poisson assume, and is the assumption true of words in a text?
8. What is a correlation coefficient? What does $r = -0.243$ actually look like?
9. Correlation is not causation. **What is it, then**, and what can you do with one?
10. What is a confidence interval, and why does this project never report one?
11. What is multiple comparisons, and why does 50 predictions with no correction matter?
12. What is an effect size, and how is it different from a p-value?
13. What is a one-tailed against a two-tailed test, and which is this project using?
14. What is a rate, and why is a ratio not the same as a difference?
15. What does "the median is 2" tell you about the shape of a distribution?

16. Who was René Girard? Dates, nationality, discipline, where he taught.
17. What does "mimetic" mean, and where does the word come from?
18. Is Girard a philosopher, an anthropologist, or a literary critic? Why does it matter?
19. What is the standing of mimetic theory in anthropology today? Be honest.
20. Who are the main critics by name, and what is their discipline?
21. What is "archaic religion" and what does Girard mean by "the sacred"?
22. What did Frazer and Lévi-Strauss say, and how is Girard different?
23. Where does Freud come in, and what is the narcissism of small differences?
24. What is Girard's own religious position, and does it change how you read him?
25. What are Girard's main books, in order, and which one is this project using?
26. What does "the founding murder" claim, and what kind of evidence could it ever have?
27. Is Girard's theory falsifiable **as he states it**, or only as this project restates it?

28. What is a Greek tragedy structurally? What is a chorus, a messenger speech?
29. What is the *Bacchae* about and roughly when was it written?
30. What is *Oedipus the King* about, and what does the audience already know?
31. What is the *Odyssey*, and why is it a control rather than a test text?
32. Who are Apollodorus and Diodorus, and what is "mythography"?
33. What is Ovid's *Metamorphoses* and why is it cut into 31 pieces here?
34. What is the Passion, for a viewer who does not know it?
35. What are the ASV and the KJV, and why does the project use two translations?
36. Why is everything in this corpus a **translation**, and what does that cost?
37. What is Project Gutenberg and why does it decide what is in the corpus?

38. What is git, and what is a commit? What does it actually guarantee?
39. What is a hash, and what does sha256 give you that a filename does not?
40. What is an HTML entity and why did 3,037 of them break the denominator?
41. What is a script, and what does it mean that "the scorer did not exist yet"?
42. What is pre-registration in medicine, and what is it for?
43. What does "operationalise" mean, and why is it the step where results get decided?
44. What is a held-out sample, and why can you not test on what you trained on?
45. What is a control group, and what is it controlling **for**?

Checked 15 Aug 2026, after the questions were frozen

Most items are covered somewhere. **The ones below are not**, and they were found by checking rather than by remembering, which is why the list is worth more than the pass rate.

#	THE GAP	WHY IT IS LOAD-BEARING
16	no biography of Girard anywhere in 50 episodes	a series about a man that never says who he was, when he lived, or what he was a professor of
19, 20	the standing of mimetic theory, and no critic is named	episode 14 is called <i>who says he is wrong</i> and names nobody
21, 22	archaic religion, Frazer, Lévi-Strauss	the theory is a reply to them and the reply is never located
13	one-tailed against two-tailed	never mentioned once , and it halves or doubles every p-value in the project
5	where 0.05 comes from	quoted twice, never examined
2	standard deviation	z is taught as "typical wobbles", the underlying quantity never is
1	median rather than mean	every headline number is a median and the choice is never defended
10	confidence intervals	never reported, and the reason is never given
35	ASV and KJV	the translation control is the most load-bearing number in the project and the two translations are never identified

Read 16 and 20 together. The series spends fifty episodes testing one man's theory, has a whole episode on his critics, and a viewer finishes it unable to say who he was or name one person who disagrees with him.

Say **these on camera when the term first appears**. They are not scripts, they are the answers you should have cold. **Anything marked tier K is a lead**, and by this series' own rule it does not get stated as fact until somebody opens a source.

Girard, the man

René Girard, 1923 to 2015. French. Born in Avignon. Trained as an **archivist and medieval historian** at the École des Chartes, moved to the United States in 1947, and spent his career there.

He held chairs in French literature, at Johns Hopkins, SUNY Buffalo, and finally **Stanford**, where he was professor of French language, literature and civilization. **Elected to the Académie française in 2005.**

He was a literary critic by post, doing anthropology of religion by inclination, and that mismatch is the single most useful fact about his reception. **He was never an anthropologist**, and anthropologists have generally not adopted him.

The books, in order, with the English titles this series uses:

FRENCH	ENGLISH	WHAT IT DOES
<i>Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque</i> , 1961	<i>Deceit, Desire and the Novel</i>	mimetic desire, read out of novels
<i>La Violence et le sacré</i> , 1972	<i>Violence and the Sacred</i>	the mechanism, sacrifice, archaic religion
<i>Des choses cachées...</i> , 1978	<i>Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World</i>	the whole system, in dialogue form
<i>Le Bouc émissaire</i> , 1982	<i>The Scapegoat</i>	the four stereotypes. Chapter 2
<i>Je vois Satan tomber comme l'éclair</i> , 1999	<i>I See Satan Fall Like Lightning</i>	the dissent claim. Pages 3 and 122

The standing of the theory, said honestly

Mimetic theory is not mainstream anthropology. It has a serious following in literary criticism, in theology, and among readers outside the academy, and a dedicated society and journal. **It is not the working framework of the field whose subject matter it claims to explain.**

Say that plainly rather than implying consensus. It also cuts the other way, and the honest form of the defence is: an outsider's theory being unadopted is not the same as its being refuted, and the project exists because the usual reason given for not adopting it is that it cannot be tested.

Naming individual critics is a research task nobody has done. Episode 14 states five objections by content and **names no one**. Until somebody sources them, **the objections are tier K as attributions** even though the arguments are real. Do not invent a name on camera.

What Girard is replying to

Frazer, *The Golden Bough*: sacrifice as magic and fertility, the dying and returning king, religion as failed proto-science. **Girard keeps Frazer's observation that the king is a victim and rejects the magical explanation.**

Lévi-Strauss, structuralism: a myth's meaning is in its **structure**, in oppositions and transformations, not in any event behind it. **This is the direct rival.** Girard's claim is that there is a real event behind the myth and the structure is the scar left by it. **Lévi-Strauss thinks looking for the event is a category mistake.**

Freud, *Totem and Taboo*: the primal horde kills the father. **Girard is explicitly building on and against this.** The narcissism of small differences is Freud's, and Girard's version is **structural rather than psychological**: the conflict is produced by the collapse of difference, not by a drive. **Tier K, both Freud references, until somebody opens the essays.**

"**Archaic religion**" means the sacrificial religions preceding and outside the biblical tradition, taken as a class. "**The sacred**" in Girard is not a feeling of holiness. It is the ambivalent power attributed to the victim afterwards: **both the cause of the disaster and the source of the peace**, which is why archaic gods are so often both.

The statistics you are assumed to know

Standard deviation. The typical distance of a value from the average of its group. If the fake results average -0.16 with a standard deviation of 2.95 , then a typical fake lands about three either side of zero. **z is just "how many of those typical distances away am I."**

Median rather than mean, and why every headline here is a median. The mean is dragged by extreme values; the median is not. **These distributions are skewed** — a few texts score enormously and most score low — so a mean would report a number no actual text is near. **It is the right choice and the project never defends it.**

One-tailed against two-tailed, and this is the real gap. A two-tailed test asks "is there a difference." A one-tailed test asks "is it bigger, in the direction I predicted." **This project makes directional predictions throughout** (Gospel above myth, tragedy above myth), so its tests are one-tailed.

That matters and it is never said. A one-tailed p-value is **half** its two-tailed equivalent for the same data. Anybody recomputing these numbers two-tailed gets different figures, and the pre-registrations do not state the choice. **Say it out loud before somebody in the comments does.**

Where 0.05 comes from. Fisher, as a convenience, roughly a century ago. **It has no principled basis**, it is not a property of the world, and the project uses it because everyone does. **A result at 0.049 and one at 0.051 are the same result**, which is the question already asked in Season 3 episode 9.

Confidence intervals, and why there are none here. An interval expresses the precision of an **estimate**. Almost everything here is a **comparison against a null** rather than an estimate of a quantity, so the natural summary is the null distribution itself. **That is a defensible reason and the project never gives it**, and the honest addition is that

intervals on the tier medians would have made the 0.07 mythography gap visibly meaningless years earlier.

Multiple comparisons. Fifty predictions at 0.05 means about two and a half false passes expected **even if nothing is true anywhere**. The project applies no correction. **Why it matters less here:** multiplicity inflates **false positives**, and this project's problem is that almost everything **failed**. You cannot have many false passes when you have few passes. **It would matter enormously if the record were the other way round.**

Effect size against p-value. The p-value says how surprising the result is if nothing is going on. **The effect size says how big it is.** A huge sample makes tiny effects significant; a small sample leaves large effects insignificant. **Season 3 episode 8's whole argument is an effect-size argument** — 0.5% inside a 17% wobble — made without ever using the term.

Correlation, and what $r = -0.243$ looks like. A correlation runs from -1 to $+1$. **0.243 is weak:** a faint tendency visible only in aggregate, invisible in any individual text, and it explains about **6%** of the variation. **Report it as a hint, never as a mechanism.**

The texts and the tools

ASV and KJV. The **American Standard Version, 1901**, and the **King James Version, 1611**. Both are **out of copyright**, which is the entire reason they are the two translations in this project. **The translation control in Season 3 episode 5 compares two Bible translations and never names them on camera.**

Why everything is a translation, and the cost: no Greek is scored anywhere in this project. **Every number is a measurement of English**, produced by translators working between 1611 and 1921 with their own habits. Season 3 episode 5 is the only check on this and it has a sample size of one.

A messenger speech is a convention of Greek tragedy: violence happens offstage and a messenger comes on to describe it. **This is why the Bacchae's killing is 600 words in a 17,180-word play** — the form requires it to be reported rather than shown, and the instrument's dilution problem is partly a fact about the genre.

A chorus is the group that comments on the action, often the community's voice. **For a Girardian reading that is not decoration:** it is the crowd, on stage, saying what the crowd thinks.

Git, a commit, and what it guarantees. A commit is a dated snapshot of every file. **It guarantees the order in which things were written down. It does not guarantee the order in which things were known**, which is exactly the distinction Season 2 episode 3 is built on.

Operationalise means turning a claim into a procedure that produces a number. **It is the step where results are decided**, because the claim is settled in prose and the procedure is what actually runs.